to some of us who had managed to set up an impromptu interaction with him.

These interactions made me realize that there were people who were deeply invested in moral, intellectual and ideological aspects of politics in the Congress as well. In fact, the malaise of small talk, I realized with time, was not restricted to this party alone, but a feature of all mainstream politics. This was because most mainstream politics is driven not by the quest for some ideal, but by the ruthless pursuit of power and instinct for self-preservation. The realm of power inevitably gives rise to relationships based on shared interests that lack depth, while the realm of ideas enables one to forge meaningful relationships based on shared values and utopias.

However, while there were people at all levels who were engaged in serious ideological work, they coexisted with those who did not share their convictions. It was the choice of the individual as to which path they would take. I decided that politics was only worth taking up if it was anchored within some ideological, intellectual and moral project. Otherwise, it was just time spent away from people who actually loved you in the hope of getting the fickle affection of strangers. The Yatra helped me gain clarity about what kind of politics I would pursue, and why.

Fighting for Bandhutva

Politics without ideology is nothing but a gang war. A formation that does not fight for any ideas or values but only competes for power is not a political party but a mafia. The Bharat Jodo Yatra helped forge a new ideological consensus to respond to the politics of social and economic polarization built on the pretext of establishing a Hindu nation. It provided an alternative vision of the nation and a vocabulary of nationalism. We need to draw upon our history and rebuild the nation with the idea of Bandhutva, or fraternity, rather than Hindutva.

In retrospect, it is clear that the Yatra was stupendously successful in transforming the political discourse of the country. When we were about to